



Thematic curriculum and mother tongue education in Uganda: discrepancies between *de jure* and *de facto* language-in-education policy

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Outline

This paper reports on the work in progress regarding mother tongue (MT) education and the transition to English in Uganda.

Aims:

- To show the expectations of MT policy and thematic curriculum
- **Findings:**
 - Teachers' perceptions and practices in schools vis-à-vis policy and curriculum
 - Some issues that have caused the discrepancy between stated policy and policy in practice

Problem overview

- In many African countries, poor levels of literacy acquisition have invoked MT education curricula with a hope of enhancing literacy skills and L2 acquisition.
- MT education was reintroduced in Uganda in 2006/2007 motivated by poor literacy acquisition
- As teachers are at the centre of language policy implementation, a study to explore how they understand and manage the process of transition from MT to English is in order.

Motivation

- Findings related to pupils' literacy skills in Uganda (UNEB, 2010, 2011; Piper, 2010)
- Research findings on learners instructed in MT in the early years of schooling: they learn faster and easier.

With operationalization of MT education one would expect Ugandan learners to perform better but it is not the case.

Language-in-education policy

The operational policy orients itself to an **early-exit transitional model:**

- Rural schools select a dominant local language to use as LoLT from primary (P) 1 - P.3
- **P.4 is a transitional year**
- P.5 - P.7, English as LoLT, MT as subject
- Urban schools use English as LoLT because they are assumed to be too multilingual.

Hopes and Expectations of MT policy

- Curriculum and MT education planners predicted that learners, by end of P.3 would have a working vocabulary of 800 words in English (NCDC, 2008)
- English would be the LoLT from P.5 - P.7
- MT would be taught as subject all through
- All learning materials would be provided in learners' MT (NCDC, 2006a).

MT policy hopes & expectations compared to research findings

- We know that early-exit models are criticized for taking away MT so early before learners have mastered L2 (Benson, 2008; Heugh, 2011...)
- Evidence suggests: by end of P.3, learners would have a vocabulary of between 500-600 words in English (Heugh, 2006, 2011); the working vocabulary for LoLT is 7000-8000 words (van Ginkel, 2011)

Method

- This is a **multi-method triangulation study** (September - November 2012)
- **Conducted in 10 schools, 3 districts:** 2 government and 2 private in Rakai rural district; 4 rural government schools in Oyam district, northern Uganda; and 2 urban schools from Kampala (capital of Uganda).
- **Methods:**
 - Questionnaires
 - Classroom observations
 - Follow-up interviews
 - Document analysis

Findings: a comparison of government and rural private schools

No	Item/Factor	Government school	Private school
1	MT teaching and as LoLT	- MT as LoLT, P.1 – P.3 - MT as subject, P.1 – P.3 - MT as subject not given attention (?)	- English as LoLT throughout - MT as subject, P.1 – P.3 - <i>Why not MT as LoLT?</i>
	Language profiles were collected (?)		

Findings – cont'd

Item/factor	Gov't school	Private school
Use of English as LoLT	Not possible to use English as LoLT after P.3 – learners have not mastered English	Codeswitching between English and MT (Luganda)

Because of limited sensitization, teachers revealed that parents think that MT education was intended to fail their children.

Number of learners in gov't and private rural schools – Rakai district

Classes	School A (gov't)	School B (gov't)	School C (private)	School D (private)
P.1	24	34	90	47
P.2	14	36	87	65
P.3	17	44	104	84
P.4	6	35	92	71
P.5	8	27	75	70

Why this enrolment? School A, no P.7

Government school buildings



Private school buildings



Teacher qualification: private school

QUALIFICATION

111	12006	13247
111	12008	
111	12008	
111	12008	

Nursery Certificate
Nursery Certificate
Nursery Certificate
A Level
er A Level
n O Level
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kson O Level

Extract: school B, P.4 – why not teach MT as subject?

₁T: Since we are quite few just as you have observed the number of teachers, we concentrate on what is to be **examined**; that is where our energies are rested. You find that subjects are given names such as major and minor subjects.

₂MS: Yes

₃T: **If a child is badly off in mathematics, it is very difficult for one to leave mathematics and instead teach Luganda.**

₄MS: Yes

₅T: **And yet we do not anticipate anybody to examine** Luganda. That is one of the reasons that demotivate the teaching of Luganda as a subject.

Other issues causing discrepancy

Nursery schooling:

Implication to MT teaching

- Rural government schools do not have nursery sections
- Children join P.1 at age 6 or 7

- All private schools have nursery sections
- Children join nursery at age 3 or 4
- English is the LoLT in nursery

Government schools want to teach through English so that their learners can be at same footing with those in private schools.

Example: 3 years of learning English as subject not enough

Extract: *Taken from school A, P.4/5*

T: Ne bwe baba bakuwaana batya nti osomesa Oluzungu [laughs] nga tozzeeko mu lulimi lwe n'omubuulira kino kye kino ne bw'oleeta ebyokulabirako bitya, ayinza obutaggyaamu.

Even when you are praised as the best English teacher (*laughs*) if you do not make use of the learners' language to tell them what it is that you are teaching, however much you bring in examples, a learner may not pick anything.

Learners: inadequate fluency in English after P.4.

Example

Learners in gov't schools after P.3 have their English receptive skills more developed than oral skills. E.g. a P.4 learner asked to tell time:

T: So you are the school time keeper?

₂L: Yes

₃T: What is the time?

₄L: *Nnya kitundu*

Ten thirty.



Inadequate and uneven distribution of curriculum materials

- Some thematic areas do not have reference materials; do not come on time;
- Government schools have different materials from those of private schools
- The available materials are too shallow and repetitive
- Private schools are said to possess better curriculum materials from which examinations are set.

Summary/conclusions

- Private schools' failure to use MT as LoLT is a constructed problem (?)
- Non-examinations of MT at end primary schooling distracts MT teaching
- Three years of learning English as subject is not enough.
- There is a gap between teacher training and policy demands: there are 6 (UNEB, 2012) Ugandan local languages that are examinable at Ordinary level, yet 35 (Kateeba, 2009) are listed as LoLT in primary (?)

Suggestions

- There is a need to carryout a country-wide linguistic repertoires in schools and communities
- Need to examine MT at end of primary schooling
- Need to modify current language policy to allow more time of learning English and at the same time introduce and/or formalize bilingual education (cf. Banda, 2009, 2010)
- Need for a language policy that runs from pre-primary to primary



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